prostate cancer). With no abdication provision in place, the cabinet approved legislation permitting the move, sending it to the National Diet for passage. The emperor's announcement was carefully telegraphed beforehand, and while shocking to many, it nonetheless raised no questions or doubts about the future of the imperial system. As anachronistic as the system is, it is also an indelible part of contemporary Japan. Indeed the whole object of the 1868 Meiji Restoration, at least symbolically, was to rescue the imperial family from centuries of virtual imprisonment and elevate it to be the benign ruler of a modernizing nation that had overthrown seven hundred years of feudal control. It is this straddling of past and present, of manufactured tradition and political impotence, of unique roles and dutiful service, that explains the perseverance of the imperial family and its near-universal acceptance by the Japanese people.

The ambiguous role of the imperial family perhaps explains, or even mirrors, the continued tension in Japan between tradition and modernity. Unlike British monarchs, who touch ancient tradition only when crowned, Japanese emperors are surfeited on a near-daily basis with ceremonies that purport to reach back to the beginnings of the Japanese nation. Far more than other noble families, the imperial family continues in a private yet well-acknowledged capacity to intercede between their people and the gods, though like their foreign counterparts they too cut ribbons and attend exhibitions. Such juxtapositions, extending to religious and philosophical syncretism of widely divergent systems, has long fascinated and perplexed Western observers of Japan.

If aspects of premodern Japan linger in its culture, or are hidden in small villages and city side streets alike, then perhaps there is some connection with the continued existence of the imperial system. As a reminder of a premodern era—one that Japanese often mythologize as "purer" or simpler—the imperial family plays a cultural and moral role, in a way as the conscience of a nation forever reinventing itself, at least on the surface. The self-identity of the imperial family itself is hard to pin down. Is it the ancient and sacral representative of the Japanese